Stop

Check your emotions. If a claim causes strong emotion – anger, glee, pride, vindication – STOP. You must fact-check this claim. Remember from the chapter, Our Mental Shortcuts, that we more readily accept information that confirms our beliefs (confirmation bias) and we tend to think less critically about that kind of information than we do about information that challenges our beliefs (motivated reasoning.) A strong emotional reaction is a sign that these cognitive biases are at work. Remember, these mental shortcuts don't make us bad people, we all have them. But we do need to account for them if we want to move toward better information.

In addition, if you get lost while working on the other moves, or hit dead ends, or find yourself going down an increasingly confusing rabbit hole during your investigation, STOP. Back up and start over knowing what you know now. You're likely to take a more informed path with different search terms and better decisions.

In these chapters we're focusing on researching a wicked problem, but the SIFT method is a great thing to use before you share information on social media. Often we feel compelled to share the things that evoke the strongest feelings, but those strong feelings are a good sign that those things need to be checked before they are shared.